Part I: The Question That Would Not Stay Small

Foreword: why this began

I did not set out to write about the end of the world.

I set out to answer a question about evangelism, and I could not answer it.

The question came from a relative, over several days, and it had two halves. Does every follower of Yeshua carry the same obligation to go and tell people about Him? And how does somebody end up reading prophecy the way I had started reading it, as mostly behind us rather than mostly ahead?

I answered both. That is the part worth admitting. I answered at length, with verses, more than once. He pressed Mark 16 and Matthew 28 at me; I came back with differentiated gifts and with a conviction that the commission had already been carried out in the first century. Neither of us moved.

Nothing was settled, because nothing was being tested. We were trading citations and calling it a conversation.

Then he asked me how I had arrived at my reading of prophecy, and I could not tell him. Not because there was no answer, but because there was no short one, and because I had never once laid it out in order.

So I stopped defending it and went looking for a way to settle questions like that which did not depend on who had memorized more.

That is the honest beginning. It is not the whole beginning.

The first time anyone put Revelation in front of me I was in Washington, DC, around 2001. Somebody I knew from class asked whether I had read it. I had not. I am not sure I could have told you what it was.

Then I read it.

I cannot pin the year down better than that. I have left the uncertainty in rather than rounding it off into a date I do not actually have.

What followed was not twenty-five years of scholarship. It was questions, then life, then faith, then more attention and less attention, then things learned and forgotten and learned again. Convictions challenged. Scripture picked back up. Hot and cold, milk long before meat, always coming back.

The tools I had for the last stretch of it changed what was practically possible, and pretending otherwise would be dishonest. I could pull up a Greek text in seconds that I would once have needed a library and a week to see at all. I am not going to claim I did this the way somebody did it in 1890.

The other half is just as true. The tools sped the investigation up. They did not manufacture the twenty-odd years of questions that produced it. A machine can hand you the Greek. It cannot hand you the reason you wanted to look.

Leaving out either half would be a lie in a different direction, so both are here.

Early on, the method I had built produced a result I did not want.

I had said, out loud and more than once, that preaching was not my thing. Some people are wired for it. I am not. That was settled, it was comfortable, and it was mine.

Then I followed Acts through in order. Acts 8 says that when the believers were scattered they went everywhere announcing the word. Not the apostles. The apostles are the ones who stayed. It was the ordinary scattered believers who talked.

That did not fit what I had said about myself. And it was worse than that, because it was his verse. He had quoted Acts 8:4 at me weeks earlier and I had talked my way around it. Meeting it again in its own context, in sequence, with nobody arguing with me, was not the same experience at all.

I want to be careful here, because it is the first place this book asks you to trust it. The finding did not turn out to be a flat

obligation on everyone to do the same thing. Later work made it considerably more careful than that, and Chapter 6 shows why. But it cost me the easy version of my own position in about the second week, using a method I had built so that it could not be bent to protect me.

If a method never costs its owner anything, it is not a method. It is a defense.

So that is the book. An investigation, run in order, with the failures left in.

You will watch me be wrong about a Greek verb and correct it, and then watch the correction hand me a better piece of evidence than the mistake had, one that pointed away from the reading I preferred. You will watch a theory I would have liked to be true get investigated at length and rejected, because the evidence for it was weak and the evidence against it proved decisive, and because I do not get to throw out weak evidence when it is somebody else's and keep it when it is mine.

You will also watch me reach the end without the answer people most want.

I can tell you with real confidence that a great deal of what I was handed as future was spoken to a first-century audience

about first-century events. I can show you why. I can show you what would have to be true for me to be wrong about it.

I cannot tell you where we are standing now. Not with the confidence I would need to put it in print. The last chapter puts a marker on a chain of events and the marker is a question mark. I left it there on purpose. Inventing certainty at the last minute would undo what everything before it was for.

I am not asking you to believe any of this because I wrote it.

I am asking you to check it.

A note to the reader

A few things before we start, so you know what you are holding.

This is an investigation rather than a report on one. I did not know the ending when I began. You will meet the material roughly in the order I met it, including the parts where I had to go back and fix something. Where I moved a chapter out of the order I actually worked in, I say so in the chapter and tell you why.

You do not need to know any of this already. If you could not presently say who Ezekiel was, or what the Septuagint is, or why anybody cares what happened in Jerusalem in the year 70, the short orientation pages ahead are for you. Nothing here requires Greek or Hebrew. Where the wording of a verse is doing real work, I print the original, transliterate it, and say plainly what it establishes, what it merely allows, and what it does not establish at all.

Not every claim in this book carries the same weight, and I have tried hard not to let them blur. There is a difference between a verse that says something outright and my reconstruction of what a run of verses implies. There is a difference between a reconstruction I find convincing and a guess I am willing to test. And there is a difference between any of those

and the answer “I do not know,” which shows up in here more than once and is not an apology when it does.

So you will see six kinds of statement, and I keep them apart: what the text says explicitly, what follows by strong cumulative inference, what I hold as a probable reconstruction, what is historical observation, what is still a hypothesis, and what is an open question. If I ever quietly move one of those up a level because a paragraph lands better that way, I have cheated, and you are entitled to say so.

The failures are in here on purpose. Several attractive explanations get tested in these pages and fail. At least one of them would have solved a real problem for the position I end up holding, and I rejected it anyway, because I do not get to use a lower standard of evidence on the ideas that happen to help me. Those parts are not padding. They are the best evidence I have that the method was real.

The ending does not resolve. I reach a conclusion I can defend about where a great deal of prophecy was aimed. I do not reach a conclusion about where we are standing right now, and the last chapter says so in as many words. If you want a book that tells you what year it is on God’s calendar, this is not it, and I would be careful with the one that is.

The thing I most want you to take from this is not my conclusion.

You might finish and still disagree with me about the millennium. That is a reasonable place to land. But if you finish it asking, of any passage anyone hands you: who was speaking, who was being addressed, what did these words mean in the language they were written in, what earlier Scripture is being invoked, what was happening around the people who first heard it, is the text explaining its own symbol, am I importing something modern, what here is explicit and what is inference and what is guesswork, and am I willing to say I do not know? Then the book did something more useful than winning its original argument.

I am not asking you to adopt these conclusions because I wrote them.

Check the passages. Check the context. Check the languages and the history. Authority belongs to the Word of Yah, not to this book.

Chapter 1: the trigger

The question came from a relative, and it was not a friendly abstraction. It was aimed at me.

He had been reading about carrying a burden for people who are lost, the kind of burden that keeps a person awake, and he meant it. Then he put a verse in front of me.

> Go into all the world and proclaim the good news to every creature (Mark 16:15)

And then, plainly, without dressing it up: *with what you know, you could go out and teach the good news to people who are lost. You could preach on buses and in parks. Don't you have that burden?*

That is a real question from a real person who was not trying to score a point. I want to keep that in view, because it would be easy to turn him into a debating position, and he was not one.

I answered in four words.

Predicar no es lo mío. Preaching isn't my thing.

WHAT I MEANT, AND WHAT I HAD READY

I did not mean that I was refusing to obey God, and when I saw how it landed I said so at length.

What I meant was that I did not believe I had been given the calling of a preacher. I believed I should love people, live according to His word, and be ready to explain the hope in me when the opportunity came. And I had verses for that.

> Always be prepared to make a defense to anyone who asks you for a reason for the hope that is in you (1 Peter 3:15)

> Are all apostles? Are all prophets? Are all teachers? (1 Corinthians 12:29)

> And he gave the apostles, the prophets, the evangelists, the shepherds and teachers (Ephesians 4:11)

Read that group on its own and a real picture forms. Gifts are handed out unevenly. Evangelist appears as a specific function, which suggests not everyone holds it. And Peter's instruction is not go find people and start talking; it is be ready when someone asks.

He had verses too, and he kept producing them.

> Whoever knows the right thing to do and fails to do it, for him it is sin (James 4:17)

> Not everyone who says to me, Lord, Lord, will enter the kingdom of heaven, but the one who does the will of my Father (Matthew 7:21)

> Go therefore and make disciples of all nations (Matthew 28:19)

> Those who were scattered went about preaching the word (Acts 8:4)

Two stacks of verses. Both real. Both in the same book.

I want to be careful about that last one, because it comes back. Acts 8:4 was quoted at me in that conversation, by him, as an argument I was expected to answer. I answered around it. Chapter 4 is where I finally met it in its own context and it did something to me that it had not done sitting in a message on my phone.

AND I HAD A SECOND ARGUMENT, WHICH IS THE MORE INTERESTING ONE

There was another layer to my position, and it is the layer that eventually turned into this book.

I was reading the Great Commission as something that had already been carried out. Not cancelled. Fulfilled, in the first century, by the people it was given to. And I had texts for that too, which I brought out early:

> This good news of the kingdom will be proclaimed in all the world as a testimony to all nations, and then the end will come (Matthew 24:14)

> the good news that has come to you, as indeed in all the world (Colossians 1:6)

> the good news that you heard, which has been proclaimed in all creation under heaven (Colossians 1:23)

> Their voice has gone out to all the earth (Romans 10:18)

So my answer to *go into all the world* was not really *I am not gifted for it*. Underneath, it was: *that was accomplished*.

That is the position I actually walked in with. It is worth saying plainly because both halves of it are about to cost me something.

WHAT I WAS ACTUALLY DOING

I was not about to persuade him, and he was not about to persuade me.

If he came back with three more verses, I would go looking for four. The exchange had a shape, and the shape was that whoever runs out of ammunition first concedes, and whoever concedes is taken to have been wrong.

That is not an argument. It is an inventory contest.

The problem is not that the verses are fake. Every verse in both stacks is really there. The problem is that stacking them tells you nothing, because there is no step in the procedure where evidence decides anything. There is only a step where somebody gets tired.

And I had a second move available that was worse, though it did not feel worse at the time. When a text was pressed on me, I could reach for the framework instead of the text. *That was fulfilled in the first century.* Which may even be true, and this book spends a long time on whether it is. But used the way I was using it, it was not an answer. It was a way of not having to give one.

I had been calling all of this Bible study for a long time.

THE QUESTION THAT ACTUALLY STARTED THE BOOK

Then he asked me something else, and it is the reason you are holding this.

He wanted to know how I had arrived at the way I was reading prophecy. Which author. Which teacher. Which commentary.

And I could not answer him.

Not because there was no answer, but because there was no short one. It had come from years of reading, comparing passages, looking things up, changing my mind, praying about it,

and holding pieces together that I had never once laid out in order. I told him honestly that any two-message reply would leave out the context and just generate more questions.

Then I said that I had started, that same day, trying to organize it, because I had never written it down.

That is the true first sentence of this project. Not a decision to write a book. Somebody asked me to show my work, and I discovered I could not.

THREE THINGS I COULD NOT ANSWER EITHER

Once I stopped trying to hold my ground, some questions surfaced that I had never actually asked.

The first was about audience. Matthew 28 is spoken to somebody. Not to nobody, and not, in the first instance, to me. There are people in the room. I had been answering that verse for days without once checking who was standing in front of the person who said it.

The second was about meaning. All nations. All the world. I was leaning hard on Colossians saying the good news had gone out into all the world, and I knew what that phrase meant to me, standing in the twenty-first century with a map of the whole earth in my head. I had no idea what it meant to Paul. I had never asked. I had just loaned him my map.

The third was about categories. What kind of thing is a commission? An office given to particular people for a particular

task, the way a king commissions an envoy? Or a standing order to a whole community forever? Those are different things, the difference decides the whole argument, and I had never separated them.

None of those is a question about the end of the world. That comes later, and it comes uninvited. They are all questions about reading.

WHY I STOPPED

I told him I would organize it properly.

That sounds smaller than it felt. What I meant was that I had noticed my method was broken, and that a method that could not settle this could not be trusted on anything else either, including the parts of my position I liked.

That is the trap in proof-texting. It can arrive at a true conclusion. It just cannot tell you whether it did, because the procedure has no way to distinguish “this is correct” from “I found more verses.”

So there were two options. Keep defending and hope. Or go build a way of settling questions like this before returning to this one, so that whatever I built could not quietly be bent toward the answer I already liked.

I picked the second. It took much longer than I expected, and it is the next chapter.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. A relative pressed the outward-proclamation side with Mark 16, Matthew 28, James 4:17 and Acts 8:4. I answered that preaching was not my calling, from 1 Peter 3:15, 1 Corinthians 12 and Ephesians 4:11, and underneath that I was treating the Great Commission as already fulfilled in the first century. Neither of us could settle it, because proof-texting cannot adjudicate between two stacks of real verses, and because I had a framework I could reach for whenever a text got uncomfortable.

THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES. He asked me how I had reached my reading of prophecy and I could not answer in any short way. So the question became: what method would let this be settled by evidence rather than by whoever cites last?

"ALL NATIONS" AND "ALL THE WORLD" — NOT YET EXAMINED

I have quoted "all nations" and "all the world" in this chapter without examining either, and so has he. That is deliberate. It is how both of us were using them at the time. Whether those phrases meant to their first hearers what they mean to a modern reader turns out to be one of the largest questions in this book, and it is not settled until Chapter 23.

Chapter 2: building the method before touching the controversy

I did something here that I want to explain before I describe it, because on its face it looks like procrastination.

I did not go back to the evangelism question. I spent weeks building a way of answering questions, generally, about anything in Scripture. Only then did I return.

The reason is simple. If I had built the method while working on the question, I would have built a method that gave me the answer I wanted. Not on purpose. That is the problem with doing it on purpose being the only failure mode people watch for. You do not notice yourself choosing the tools that produce the result you already like. You notice that the tools feel right.

So the method got built first, on passages I had no stake in, and by the time it reached the contested material it was already load-bearing and I could not quietly adjust it.

FOUR BOXES

The first thing was embarrassingly simple. I made four containers and agreed to keep things in the right one.

Convictions are things I hold as taught by Scripture. Observations are things about history or the world that I can check. Hypotheses are ideas I am testing and have not established. Open questions are things I do not know.

That sounds trivial. It is not, because the ordinary way of thinking about the Bible lets these leak into each other constantly. A hypothesis that I have repeated to myself for six years starts feeling like a conviction. An observation somebody told me in a sermon starts feeling like a text. The boxes exist to make the leak visible.

Every claim in this book still sits in one of those boxes, and I tell you which.

A TEST FOR A PASSAGE

Then a sequence for working through any given passage. Text first, meaning the words that are actually there. Then context, the paragraph and the argument it sits inside. Then the rest of Scripture. Then covenant and history, meaning who these people were and what agreement they understood themselves to be living under. Then interpretation, which is mine and is labeled as mine. Then application. Then a test, which asks what would show me I am wrong.

The last step is the one people skip, including me, and it is the only one that separates study from confirmation.

FOUR KINDS OF THING, NEVER MIXED

Alongside that, a rule about categories. There is the text. There is my interpretation of the text. There is a historical correlation, meaning some event in the world that seems to line up with the text. And there is a hypothesis.

These get collapsed all the time. Somebody says the Bible predicted an event, and what they mean is that they have an interpretation of a text that correlates with a historical claim, and any of those three joints can be loose. Keeping them apart costs nothing and prevents most of the trouble I have seen in this subject.

A SCALE FOR EVIDENCE

I also needed language for how strongly a piece of evidence supported something, because "the Bible says" was doing far too much work in my vocabulary.

Four words. A piece of evidence can contradict a claim, permit it, support it, or require it. Most of what people call proof lives at **PERMITS**. Permits means the claim can survive alongside the evidence, which is a much smaller thing than it sounds like when you are the one making the claim.

I will use those four words throughout, set apart in the text like this — **CONTRADICTS**, **PERMITS**, **SUPPORTS**, **REQUIRES** — and where something only permits, I say so, even when I would rather it required.

THE BUG

Here is where the method broke, early, and I want it in the record because the fix changed how the rest of the investigation ran.

I had built the sequence as a straight line. Start with Scripture, then move outward to context, history, application. It looked disciplined. It was also wrong, and it took me a while to see why.

A straight line that starts with Scripture implies that every investigation has to begin there chronologically. But that is not how questions actually arrive. A question can come from a conversation. From something in the news. From a book. From a claim somebody made about history. From a dream, for that matter. Insisting that a real question is invalid unless it entered through a verse would have ruled out most of the questions I actually had, including the one that started this.

Scripture is foundational for deciding whether something is true. It is not necessarily where the asking begins.

So the model got rebuilt as a cycle rather than a chain, and the doorway was left open. Encounter something. Classify it. Look for what bears on it. Examine. Compare. Test. Discern. Hold it provisionally. Re-examine when something new arrives.

The word provisionally is doing real work in that list. Almost nothing in this book is held any other way.

THE QUESTION UNDERNEATH ALL OF IT

There is one diagnostic I ended up applying more than any other, and it is a single question I ask myself about a passage.

Am I discovering what this says, or am I making it carry what I brought?

The first is exegesis. The second is eisegesis. Everyone agrees the second is bad, and almost nobody catches themselves doing it, because from the inside it feels exactly like the first. It feels like the text agreeing with you.

The only defense I have found is the test step. If I cannot say what would change my mind about a reading, I am probably not reading. I am recognizing.

TWO MEN WHO HEARD FROM GOD AND GOT IT WRONG ANYWAY

The last piece of the method came from two stories, and it is the one I have leaned on hardest.

In 1 Samuel 3, a boy hears a voice. The voice is real. It is God. And Samuel gets it wrong three times, because he assumes it is Eli. He is not doubting, he is not disobedient, he is simply mistaken about what is happening. It takes Eli, from outside the experience, to tell him what the experience is.

In Acts 10, Peter has a vision. The vision is real. It is from God. And Acts 10:17 says Peter was perplexed as to what the

vision might mean. He does not know. Interpretation arrives later, from outside, when three men show up at the gate and the meaning becomes clear in the events that follow.

Two real communications from God. Two men who could not interpret them unaided. In both cases the interpretive help came from outside the experience.

I take that seriously for a reason that is not abstract. It means revelation and interpretation are not the same moment, and that being genuinely addressed by God does not by itself make you right about what He said. If Samuel and Peter needed help, my confidence about what a passage means is not self-certifying either.

That is the whole method. It is not complicated. It is mostly a set of ways to stay honest when I would rather be right.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. I could not settle the evangelism question by proof-texting, so I built a method first: four boxes to stop categories leaking, a sequence for working a passage that ends in a test, a rule against collapsing text and interpretation and historical correlation and hypothesis, a four-word scale for evidence, and a diagnostic question about whether I am reading or recognizing. One thing broke immediately. The linear model implied every investigation must begin at Scripture, which was false, and it was rebuilt as a cycle with the doorway left open.

THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES. Now the question can be asked properly. What does the commission actually say, and who was in the room?

Chapter 3: to whom was it said

The first question from the last chapter was the one about audience, so that is where I started. Who was in the room?

I need to say up front how this section came out, because the order matters. I wrote most of this chapter and then had to go back and add something at the beginning that changed how the rest of it reads. I have left the addition where it belongs rather than pretending I had it all along.

WHAT I HAD TO ADD AFTERWARD

I had been building toward a picture in which Yeshua's ministry was narrowly directed to Israel and the nations came in later, as a kind of second act. That is roughly true as a description of the sequence. It is badly misleading as a description of the intent, and I only noticed because I went looking for where the nations first appear.

They appear at the beginning.

Genesis 12:3, in the promise to Abraham: in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed. Not Abraham's family instead of the others. Through Abraham's family, the others.

Isaiah 42:6 calls the servant a light for the nations. And Isaiah 49:6 puts it in a way I had never noticed, though I had read it:

> It is too light a thing that you should be my servant to raise up the tribes of Jacob and to bring back the preserved of Israel; I will make you as a light for the nations, that my salvation may reach to the end of the earth.

Too light a thing. Restoring Israel alone is described as too small an assignment.

So the nations were never an afterthought or a fallback. They were in the commission from Genesis. What is sequenced is the order of the mission, not the scope of the intent. Holding those apart turned out to matter a great deal later, when the question became whether Gentile inclusion replaced Israel or was always the point of Israel.

THE NARROW PHASE, STATED PLAINLY

Now the part that surprised me, which is how narrow the earthly ministry actually was.

> **JOHN THE BAPTIST**
>
> A first-century Jewish prophet who called Israel to repentance and prepared the way for Yeshua. He is not the same person as John the apostle, traditionally associated with the Gospel of John and with Revelation; the two appear in this book for different reasons and I will keep them apart by name.

John the Baptist's ministry runs inside Israel and says so. He is preparing a people who already have a covenant, not recruiting a new one.

And Yeshua's own statements of scope are not ambiguous:

> Go nowhere among the Gentiles and enter no town of the Samaritans, but go rather to the lost sheep of the house of Israel (Matthew 10:5-6)

> I was sent only to the lost sheep of the house of Israel (Matthew 15:24)

I want to be careful here, because there is a strong instinct to soften those verses, and I have heard them softened in a dozen ways. They are usually treated as a temporary restriction that gets lifted, which is fine as far as it goes, or as a rhetorical setup for the Gentile who is about to be commended, which is a reading imposed from outside the sentence.

I decided to just let them say what they say. Whatever else is true, the earthly mission had a stated scope and the scope was Israel. Any account of the commission that cannot accommodate that sentence has a problem with the text, not with me.

THE EXCEPTIONS, AND WHAT SHAPE THEY HAVE

There are Gentiles in the Gospels who receive from Yeshua, and they are not incidental. A Canaanite woman presses

through a refusal. A Roman officer gets told that no such faith has been found in Israel.

What interested me was not that they exist. It was the shape of what they are told they are entering.

> Many will come from east and west and recline at table with Abraham and Isaac and Jacob in the kingdom of heaven (Matthew 8:11)

Reclining at table with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. The picture is not that the Gentile receives a different arrangement, running in parallel. It is that he arrives at the table where Israel's fathers are already seated.

That image is going to come back. Much later in this investigation, when Paul reaches for a picture of what has happened to Gentiles like me, he uses a tree that was already growing.

ONE THING I COULD NOT RESOLVE, LEFT UNRESOLVED

I ran into a contradiction at this point that I have not solved, and the honest thing is to show you where it sits rather than pick a side and move on.

Asked directly whether he is Elijah, John the Baptist says he is not (John 1:21).

Speaking about John the Baptist, Yeshua says that he is Elijah who is to come, if you are willing to accept it (Matthew 11:14).

There are respectable ways to reconcile those. John the Baptist may be denying a particular expectation, a literal returned Elijah, while affirming a functional role. Yeshua's if you are willing to accept it may be signaling something other than a flat identification. I find some of these more plausible than others.

But I do not know, and this book has a rule about that, established one chapter ago. So the texts sit side by side in my notes, unharmonized, in the open questions box.

I mention it here rather than burying it because it is the first time in the investigation that I hit something I could not settle, and the shape of what I did about it is the shape of what I keep doing about it for the rest of the book.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. The nations were in the promise from Genesis 12 onward, and Isaiah 49:6 calls restoring Israel alone too light a thing, so Gentile inclusion is not a later substitution for a failed plan. The earthly ministry nonetheless had a stated scope, and that scope was Israel, in words I am not going to soften. Gentiles who do receive in the Gospels are pictured as coming to a table that was already set.

THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES. If the mission started that narrow and the intent was always that wide, then something moved. How did it move, and when, and who did it?

Chapter 4: Acts, followed in sequence

I read Acts straight through, in order, without skipping ahead, and I want to explain why that constraint mattered before I say what came out of it.

The temptation with Acts is to read it backward. You already know Gentiles get included, so you read Peter's early sermons as though he already knows it too. You already know what the sheet vision means, so you never notice that Peter did not. Reading forward means letting the characters be as ignorant at chapter 2 as they actually were.

That constraint is most of what this chapter found.

THE BOOK ANNOUNCES ITS OWN SHAPE

Acts 1:8 gives a route. Jerusalem, then Judea and Samaria, then to the end of the earth.

Then the book follows it. Jerusalem for seven chapters. Judea and Samaria beginning in chapter 8. And outward from there until the last verse leaves Paul preaching in Rome.

That is not a small observation. Acts is structured as the fulfillment of a sentence in its own first chapter, which means

the movement outward is not accidental drift. It is the plan, executed.

WHERE I HAD BEEN READING A MAP INTO THE TEXT

Acts 2 is where I caught myself first.

Luke says there were dwelling in Jerusalem Jews, devout men, from every nation under heaven, and then lists the nations. For years I had read that as the moment the message goes out to the world, in embryo. All those nations, right there at the beginning.

But read the sentence again. It says Jews, from every nation. It is telling you where these men were from, not what covenant they stood in. The list is geography. The audience is Israel, plus proselytes.

And Peter says so, repeatedly, in the sermon itself. Men of Judea. Men of Israel. Let all the house of Israel therefore know for certain. He is not speaking to the nations. He is speaking to Israel, in Jerusalem, at a feast.

Then comes Acts 2:39, the promise is for you and for your children and for all who are far off. Far off is a phrase I badly wanted to make mean Gentiles, because I knew from elsewhere that it can.

I made myself leave it alone. Peter, at this point in the narrative, has not yet understood that Gentiles are included. That is

the whole crisis of chapter 10, eight chapters later, and it is a crisis precisely because he does not see it coming. Reading Gentiles into 2:39 requires importing what Peter learns later into a sentence he speaks earlier.

I left it and moved on. It gets vindicated in the next chapter of this book, and not by me.

THE FIRST CORRECTION

Then Acts 8, which cost me a position.

I had believed, without ever having examined it, that proclamation in the early church was essentially the work of the apostles. Everyone else believed, gathered, supported. The Twelve preached.

Acts 8:1 says that a persecution broke out and they were all scattered throughout the regions of Judea and Samaria, except the apostles.

Except the apostles. The apostles are the ones who stayed.

And then 8:4: those who were scattered went about preaching the word. The verb is εὐαγγελίζω (*euangelizō*), announcing good news. It is the ordinary scattered believers doing it, and the apostles are explicitly not among them.

So the claim that only the Twelve proclaimed does not survive contact with Acts 8. It is not weakened. It is eliminated.

I said in the foreword that the method cost me something in about the second week. This is the week.

DESCRIPTION IS NOT PROCEDURE

Something else in Acts 8 kept me from over-correcting.

In Samaria, people believe and are baptized, and the Spirit comes later, when Peter and John arrive. In Acts 10, at Cornelius's house, the Spirit falls while Peter is still talking, before anyone is baptized at all.

Those are different sequences. If I take either one as the required procedure, the other becomes a problem to be explained.

So a rule came out of it that I have used constantly since. Narrative description is not universal procedure. Luke is telling me what happened, in these places, with these people. Turning what happened into what must always happen is an extra step, and it needs its own justification every time.

That rule cuts against readings I like as often as against readings I do not.

THE CLEAREST CASE OF READING INTO A TEXT THAT I HAVE

Acts 10 is the sheet vision. A sheet comes down with animals in it, and a voice says kill and eat, and Peter refuses, and the voice says what God has made clean do not call common.

On the surface this is about food. It is full of animals. Food is right there.

Here is what stopped me. Peter tells us what it meant, in the same chapter, out loud:

> God has shown me that I should not call any person common or unclean (Acts 10:28)

Person. Not food. Peter interprets his own vision and the interpretation is about people, and when the Jerusalem believers hear the report they conclude the same thing: then to the Gentiles also God has granted repentance that leads to life (Acts 11:18).

Now, does the vision have implications for food laws? Possibly. That is a real question and I am not dismissing it. But it is a separate question, it has to be argued on its own evidence, and it cannot be smuggled in by treating the surface imagery as the meaning when the text supplies a different meaning and the characters act on that one.

I set the food question aside to be examined later, and it was, at considerable length, many chapters from here. What I

would not let it be was a conclusion I reached in chapter 10 of Acts by not listening to Peter.

AND THEN ACTS CORRECTED MY CORRECTION

This is my favorite thing that happened at this point, and it happened because I kept reading in order instead of stopping when I had a result I liked.

I had taken Acts 8:4 to mean that scattered ordinary believers were carrying the message outward, and I was pleased with it, because it had cost me something and that felt like rigor.

Acts 11:19 comes back to the same scattering:

> Now those who were scattered because of the persecution that arose over Stephen traveled as far as Phoenicia and Cyprus and Antioch, speaking the word to no one except Jews

To no one except Jews.

So the ordinary believers really were proclaiming, and my correction stands. But they were proclaiming within Israel. The outward movement to Gentiles is not what Acts 8 was describing, and I had been quietly letting it mean that.

The finding got sharper rather than reversed. I still lost the position I started with. I also lost the slightly grander version

of the position I had replaced it with, which I had held for about a day.

THE BOOK DOING WHAT I WAS TRYING TO DO

The last thing I noticed in Acts is not an argument, it is a resemblance, and I have thought about it a lot since.

In Acts 11 and again in Acts 15, the community faces something new. Someone reports an experience. The others deliberate. They go to Scripture. They reach a judgment. They revise what they had assumed.

Encounter, testimony, deliberation, Scripture, discernment, revision.

That is nearly the cycle I had built in the previous chapter, before I got here, and I did not build it from Acts. I am not going to claim that as proof of anything. It is the kind of correspondence that could be my pattern-matching rather than the text's structure, and I flagged it as such.

But it did make me more willing to trust the method, and it made the Jerusalem council in Acts 15 read very differently. Those men are not applying a settled rule. They are working something out, in public, and writing down what they conclude and why.

Acts 15 is going to matter enormously later, for reasons that have nothing to do with evangelism.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. Acts follows its own stated route outward. Acts 2's list of nations is geography, not covenant identity, and Peter is addressing Israel. Acts 8:4 eliminated the claim that only the apostles proclaimed, and then Acts 11:19 narrowed my replacement claim by showing those same scattered believers spoke only to Jews. Acts 10 gave me the clearest case I have of a surface image meaning something other than it appears, with the interpretation supplied by the character himself. And a rule fell out of the Spirit-sequence difference: description is not procedure.

> **THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES.** Luke tells me what happened. He does not tell me what it means for the covenant. So what does Paul say it means?

Chapter 5: Paul, and the terminology stress-test

Luke gave me the events. Paul is where somebody stops and says what the events mean, and he does it at greatest length in Romans 9 through 11, which is three chapters written by a Jewish man agonizing about his own people.

That is worth sitting with before reading a word of it. This is not a detached theological treatise about the status of Israel. It is a man in pain, arguing.

HE DOES NOT SAY WHAT I HALF EXPECTED

I came to Romans 9 with a vague inherited picture in which Israel had its turn, did not take it, and was replaced. I could not have told you where I got that. Nobody taught it to me in those words. It was ambient.

Romans 9 identifies the Israelites and then lists what is theirs. The adoption, the glory, the covenants, the giving of the law, the worship, the promises, the patriarchs, and from them, according to the flesh, the Messiah.

None of that is phrased as forfeited. I am not going to lean on the grammar harder than it will bear, because the list is built from noun phrases rather than from a verb doing the work, and I have seen people load more onto that construction than

it can carry. The observation stands on what is listed and on what Paul does next.

Then Romans 11:1, and Paul asks the question directly, as if he knows exactly what his reader is thinking:

> I ask, then, has God rejected his people? By no means!

That is about as close as the New Testament comes to preemptively closing a door. Whatever complicated things Paul is about to say, and he says several, he has ruled out the simple replacement reading in advance, in his own words, before making his argument.

THE TREE, WITH THE PART THAT USUALLY GETS LEFT OFF

Then the olive tree, in Romans 11:17-24, which I had heard many times.

Branches are broken off. A wild olive shoot is grafted in among the others and shares in the nourishing root. That is me. That is the whole basis on which someone like me has any standing in this story at all, and it is a generous picture.

What I had never heard quoted was what Paul does immediately afterward, which is turn and warn the graft:

> do not be arrogant toward the branches. If you are, remember it is not you who support the root, but the root that supports you.

And then, a few lines on: do not become proud, but fear.

Fear. The grafting is grounds for fear, not for superiority. Paul goes out of his way to point out that the graft is the one contrary to nature, that if God did not spare the natural branches he will not spare this one either, and that the natural branches can be grafted back in more easily than the wild one was put in.

Every emphasis in the passage runs against the reading in which Gentiles have arrived and taken over. I had received the image without the warning attached to it, and the warning is more than half the passage.

A RESTRAINT THAT PAID

In the last chapter I refused to read "all who are far off" in Acts 2:39 as Gentiles, because Peter did not know that yet, even though I knew the phrase could carry it.

Ephesians 2 uses the same language and says plainly who it means. Gentiles in the flesh, called the uncircumcision, separated from Messiah, alienated from the commonwealth of Israel, strangers to the covenants of promise. And then: but now in Messiah Yeshua you who once were far off have been brought near by the blood of Messiah.

So "far off" does mean Gentiles, and it means it on Ephesians' own authority, in a place where Paul defines his terms.

I am pointing at this because it is what the restraint is for. If I had imported the meaning into Acts 2:39 to make a point earlier, I would have had a weaker version of the same conclusion resting on a verse that did not establish it. Waiting cost nothing and produced something stronger.

THE PART WHERE I PUT MY OWN LABEL IN THE MACHINE

Now the uncomfortable section, and the reason this chapter is titled the way it is.

By this point I had started describing myself as a Messianic Israelite. It felt right. It named something I believed had happened: that I, a Gentile, had been brought into Israel's covenant story through Israel's Messiah, rather than into some separate arrangement that had superseded it.

So I ran the label through the same test I had been running on everyone else's claims.

The substance survives. Grafted into the tree, Romans 11. Fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God, Ephesians 2. No longer strangers to the covenants. One body. All of that is there and it is not marginal.

The label does not survive, or at least it does not survive as a scriptural title. Nowhere does Scripture take a Gentile who has come to Messiah and call him an Israelite. And Romans 11 keeps the natural branches and the wild branch distinct

after the grafting has occurred. Paul had every opportunity to collapse the categories and he does not. He keeps talking about them as two things joined, not one thing that absorbed the other.

That is a real result and it went against me. I did not stop using the phrase, and I explain in the last chapter of this book exactly what I do and do not mean by it. But it moved from something I thought Scripture assigned me to something I use descriptively, knowing it is my word and not the text's.

Then I applied the same rule to a word I was using much more casually.

I had been calling myself a preterist. Same test. Does Scripture assign that category, or is it my summary of a set of conclusions? Obviously the latter. Which means it can describe where I have arrived, but it cannot be allowed to decide where I arrive next.

That distinction sounds academic right now. It is not. It governs the entire second half of this book, and there is a point much later where I nearly let a label do my thinking for me and had to be pulled back by a Greek verb.

WHERE THE PRAISE GOES

One last thing, small, that I have not been able to stop thinking about.

Romans 11 ends in a doxology. Oh, the depth of the riches and wisdom and knowledge of God. How unsearchable his judgments. For who has known the mind of the Lord?

That last line is Isaiah 40:13, and Paul quotes it at the end of eleven chapters of the hardest sustained reasoning in his letters. Not instead of the reasoning. After it.

He does not reach for the unsearchability of God to avoid the argument. He argues, at length, with texts and objections and counterarguments, and then he says this is deeper than I can see to the bottom of.

I would like to do it in that order.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. Paul rules out the replacement reading explicitly in Romans 11:1, lists the covenants and the promises among the things that are Israel's in Romans 9, and attaches a warning to the olive tree that is longer than the promise. Gentile incorporation is real and substantial. The label I had been using for it is mine rather than Scripture's, which I established by testing my own vocabulary the way I had been testing everyone else's, and the same test applies to the word preterist.

> **THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES.** The foundation is now built. So, finally: what does the commission actually require of a believer today?

Chapter 6: the synthesis that cost its own author

Five chapters to get back to a question I had already answered, at length, in the space of an afternoon. That is not efficiency. It is the only way I know to get an answer worth having.

Here is what the method produced.

BOTH OF THE POSITIONS IN THAT CONVERSATION ARE WRONG

He was arguing that Yeshua commanded proclamation and that a believer who knows something ought to be carrying it outward. I was arguing that Scripture hands out gifts and callings unevenly and that mine was not evangelism.

One of those does not survive and the other needs qualifying, and I want to be exact about which is which. Mine is the one that does not survive, so I will take it first.

What dies on my side is the use I was making of differentiated ministry: that because I am not an evangelist, proclamation has nothing to do with me. Acts 8:4 kills that, as I walked through two chapters ago. The apostles stayed. The scattered ordinary believers announced. Whatever else is

true, that sentence exists, and the man who quoted it at me was not wrong to quote it.

Note what it does not settle. It does not tell me that apostolic commission and ordinary witness are the same thing, and Part IV of this book spends a long time on the difference.

What is qualified on his side is narrower than I would like it to be, and I want to be careful here, because it would be easy to hand myself a cleaner victory than the evidence gives me.

He was not claiming that every believer holds the office of evangelist. He was claiming that a believer who knows something ought to be carrying it outward, and that Yeshua commanded proclamation. Ephesians 4:11 does not touch that claim. It touches a stronger one, which he never made.

So what Paul actually rules out, three ways, is the collapse of ordinary witness into one identical evangelistic office for everybody.

Ephesians 4:11 lists evangelists as one gift among several. A list of distinct gifts in which evangelist is one item cannot mean everyone is that item.

1 Corinthians 12:29-30 asks a series of rhetorical questions with an obvious intended answer. Are all apostles? Are all prophets? Are all teachers? The expected answer is no, and 12:17 makes the underlying point with an image: if the whole body were an eye, where would the hearing be?

And Acts 21:8 mentions Philip the evangelist, using it as an identifying description, the way you would say Luke the physician. It is a designation that distinguishes him. If it applied to everyone it would identify no one.

That matters, and it is worth resisting the shape my instinct wants to give it. The clean version of this chapter has both of us equally wrong, meeting in a tidy middle. That is not what happened.

What happened is that my position failed and his position needed qualifying. Those are not the same outcome, and pretending they are would be the most flattering sentence in the book.

I could not have arrived here by counting verses, because both of us had verses. I arrived by asking what each set was actually claiming, and finding that the two sets are not answering the same question. He was answering *is proclamation for everyone*. I was answering *is the office of evangelist for everyone*. Those are different questions, and neither of us had noticed. I was defeating a claim he had not made, and losing the one he had.

WHAT REPLACES THEM IS A DISTINCTION, NOT A RULE

The finding is not a third position that splits the difference. It is a separation of two things that had been fused.

There is the question of ministry, meaning a particular calling, gifting, and role. Scripture distributes those unevenly, on purpose, and says so repeatedly. Nobody is required to be an evangelist.

Then there is the question of witness, meaning whether a believer who has been given something true is free to be silent about it as a matter of settled policy. That is a different question, and Acts 8:4 makes it hard to answer yes. They had been run out of town, and they talked.

This is a good place to slow down and say exactly what that verse carries, because I have watched myself ask it to carry more.

> **WHAT ACTS 8 BEARS**
>
> REQUIRES — proclamation was not restricted to the apostles. Acts 8:1 puts the apostles outside the scattering; Acts 8:4 has the scattered announcing the word. That is explicit and it is not negotiable.
>
> SUPPORTS — proclamation extended beyond a narrowly defined apostolic office, which is the point I actually needed and did not have.
>
> **Does not establish** — that none of those scattered believers held any particular calling. Luke's silence about what commission they understood themselves to be under is silence, not evidence of absence. And the chapter itself argues against the stronger reading: Philip is right there in Acts 8, going down to Samaria and proclaiming, and thirteen chapters later Luke calls him *Philip the evangelist*.

I had that last point backwards at first. I had the people announcing in Acts 8 as the ones Luke does not identify by office, while Acts 21:8 calls one of them Philip the evangelist. Both claims could not stand. One of them had to go, and it was not the one with a verse attached.

I had been using the first question to answer the second. That was the actual error, it was mine, and it had been comfortable for years.

There is a second error underneath it that belongs here too. Whenever a text got uncomfortable in that exchange, I could reach for the framework instead of the text and say the commission had already been carried out in the first century. Whether that is true is the subject of most of this book. But used the way I was using it, it was not an answer to Mark 16. It was a way of not needing one.

THE SENTENCE I HAD TO TAKE APART

I said in the foreword that I had told myself preaching was not my thing. The version I actually said, more than once, was in Spanish: *predicar no es lo mío*.

Taken one way, that sentence is defensible and Scripture supports it. It can mean this is not my particular ministry, I am not the evangelist in this body, that gift went elsewhere. Ephesians 4 and 1 Corinthians 12 permit that. More than permit it, they describe it.

Taken the other way, it means I have no responsibility to bear witness to what I have been shown. And I cannot get that past Acts 8:4, where believers the apostles had left behind are the ones announcing.

Same five words. Two meanings. One survives and one does not, and I had been leaning on the ambiguity without noticing, because the defensible meaning was always available if anyone pressed, while the meaning I was actually operating on was the other one.

That is the whole finding. It cost me a position I liked and did not replace it with a heavier one.

TWO PLACES I REFUSED TO TAKE HELP

While assembling this, I turned down two arguments that would have helped me, and I want them in the record because they show what the rules are for.

Mark 16:15, go into all the world and proclaim the good news, is the verse he opened with. It sits in the passage Mark 16:9-20.

That passage has a manuscript problem, and it is not a small or a contested one. Two of the earliest surviving complete Greek manuscripts, Codex Sinaiticus and Codex Vaticanus, end the Gospel at 16:8. The longer ending is present in many later manuscripts and became deeply established in the tex-

tual and church tradition. Its absence from those two early witnesses is a fact about the evidence.

I am deliberately not ranking those manuscripts against the later tradition here. That is a real argument in textual criticism, people hold serious positions on both sides of it, and my conclusion does not need me to win it.

What matters for this chapter is what I did with it, which is to stop citing Mark 16:15 as load-bearing. Not because I have concluded it is spurious. Because a claim that depends on a text with that kind of question over it is resting on something I would not accept if somebody else were resting on it.

And here is what kept me honest about it. Setting Mark 16:15 aside is convenient for me, because it was his verse and not mine. A man who finds a manuscript problem in the text his opponent is holding, and announces it, has not necessarily done anything admirable.

What makes it defensible is that it changes nothing. The Gentile mission is established by Acts, by Paul's letters, by Ephesians 2, by the Jerusalem council. Mark 16:15 was never carrying the mission, and the case against me does not weaken by an ounce when that verse is set down. If it did, I would have had to be much more suspicious of how quickly I reached for the manuscript evidence.

The second one is James 4:17. Whoever knows the right thing to do and fails to do it, for him it is sin.

He put that one to me directly, right after I said preaching was not my thing, which is probably why I remember exactly where it landed.

The verse is true. It is also doing no work in this argument, because it never mentions evangelism. It applies to whatever the right thing to do turns out to be, which is the exact question we were trying to settle. Used as evidence, it assumes the answer and then puts a verse on top of the assumption.

Good verse. Bad argument. And I have made that same bad argument at other people, which is how I recognized it.

WHY THIS CHAPTER IS HERE

I want to be plain about why this small chapter matters more than its subject does.

The method I built in Chapter 2 was built to be neutral. That is easy to claim. The only way to demonstrate it is for the method to produce a result its owner did not want, and here it did, in the second or third week, on a position I had held comfortably for years and had defended to a member of my own family.

There is an opponent in this chapter, and the method did not hand him a clean win either. His claim needed qualifying. But qualifying is not the same as dying, and mine died, on the

verse he had already put in front of me and I had walked around.

I am asking you, across the rest of this book, to accept some conclusions that a lot of people would find unusual. The only reason you have to take those seriously is if the thing producing them can be shown to bite the hand that built it.

This is the receipt. There will be others.

AND NOW THE THING I HAD BEEN AVOIDING

There is a second half to the question that started all this, and I have not touched it for five chapters.

The conversation had two halves. The first was about evangelism. The second was the one that came in sideways: how does a person end up reading prophecy as mostly accomplished rather than mostly pending?

I now had a method. I had spent five chapters watching it correct me twice and sharpen itself once. There was no longer any honest reason to leave the second question alone.

So I went to Matthew 24, which I had been quoting for years and had never once read as a whole, in order, with the audience in view.

I expected to confirm what I already thought.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. The two positions in that conversation did not fare equally. Mine failed on explicit text; his needed qualification rather than refutation, and saying otherwise would be the most flattering sentence available to me. What replaces them is a distinction rather than a rule: ministry is distributed unevenly and nobody is required to be an evangelist, while witness is a different question that Acts 8:4 makes hard to answer with a settled silence. Acts 8 is held to exactly what it carries: it requires that proclamation was not restricted to the apostles, and it does not establish that the people doing it held no calling, since Philip is standing in that same chapter. Two arguments that would have helped me were set down, one over a manuscript problem in a verse that was not mine, and one for assuming its own conclusion. The method cost its author something before it cost anyone else anything, which is the only real evidence that it was a method.

> **THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES.** The foundation is built and the second half of the original question is still sitting there. Matthew 24, read as a whole, with the audience in view.